

SECOND LANGUAGE PROFICIENCY REQUIREMENTS

All students pursuing a Thunderbird MGM degree must demonstrate proficiency in a second language.

As you prepare for your program at Thunderbird, we want to ensure that you are aware of your options for completing the second language requirement for your MGM degree before graduation. (*International students that speak English as a 2nd language - please see option #5 below.*)

You may meet this requirement in one of the following ways:

1. Participate in a Thunderbird Language Course(s)

Thunderbird currently offers language courses in Spanish, French, and Chinese. Students must successfully complete Levels 1 and 2 with a grade of B or higher to meet the requirement. This would satisfy 6 of 12 required, elective credits toward your degree.

Note: If you already have a foundation in one of the three Thunderbird-offered languages above, you may be able to waive out of Level 1. Below are the requirements for each language:

- **Spanish** – students must complete the OPI and score a level 3 or above
- **Chinese** – students must pass the final exam of the first course
- **French** – students must pass the final exam of the first course or pass the OPI with a Novice High

Please email your academic advisor, [Mitchell Lawson](#) or [Carly James](#), for further information regarding this option

- 2. Participate in a summer, intensive language program** in partnership with The Melikian Center's Critical Language Institute Students must pass with a grade of B or higher to meet the 2nd language requirement. Students may opt to earn graduate, elective credit toward their degree, or participate independently through the CLI. Please note that the cost structure differs for each program. Due to the time demands of this intensive program, this option is not suitable for students participating in the summer GCL, nor students pursuing a full-time summer internship. *Please consult your academic advisor with questions about this option.*

3. Take the OPI (Oral Proficiency Interview) Test (*see page 3 for more information*)

Native English Speakers, U.S. Permanent Residents, dual citizens or citizens of native English-speaking countries claiming fluency in a second language are required to take the OPI Test. Passing the OPI with a rating of **intermediate high for Group 1** languages or **intermediate low for Group 2** will satisfy Thunderbird's second-language graduation requirement. This must be completed no later than the end of your first semester at Thunderbird.

If you do not pass the OPI and would like to retake it, you may do so after waiting at least 30 days.

4. Submit a Certificate of Proficiency

Submit your **Foreign Service Institute or Peace Corps** language certificate dated within 12 months of starting your degree program at Thunderbird. The scores must be equivalent to

Thunderbird's requirement. *Please email your [Academic Advisor](#) if you will be submitting a Certificate of Proficiency.*

5. **International students that speak English as a 2nd language** and submitted an English Language Test (i.e. TOEFL, IELTS, PTE, or Duolingo) meeting minimum score requirements during the application process for the MGM program, will have the 2nd language requirement waived. If you did not submit a test, you can meet the requirement by submitting one of the following:
- **Transcript from a high school or college/university where English was not the primary language of instruction.** (Example: If you graduated from a high school or college where the primary language of instruction was not English, the transcript would serve as proof of second language proficiency).
 - **English Language Test results** from a reputable source such as the TOEFL, IELTS, PTE, or Duolingo. Dates of exam must fall within 5 years of admission to Thunderbird. (Example: If you submitted an English Language Test for admission to an undergraduate program in the United States, you could submit that same score to Thunderbird as proof of second language proficiency).
 - **English for Admission and Achievement certificate** after completion of the Global Launch program prior to admission.

Please email documents to your academic advisor, [Mitchell Lawson](#) or [Carly James](#).

Oral Proficiency Interview (OPI) Test

The Oral Proficiency Interview (OPI) measures a sample of speech to determine a person's expertise in a language.

About the OPI:

Thunderbird students will participate in the [Speaking and Listening Assessment](#) provided by ALTA Language Services, otherwise known as an OPI. This is a live 30-minute conversation that takes place over the phone between a trained, certified tester and the candidate. The OPI assesses a student's proficiency in oral communication. The OPI consists of several pools of prompts, with each pool targeting a specific objective (e.g. describing future plans). For this test, candidates will be speaking aloud in response to oral discussion prompts.

Although the OPI is conducted over the phone between the student and a trained ALTA certified tester, students **must** have their test proctored **in-person with a Thunderbird staff member**. Students will need to come to the Thunderbird Global Headquarters to have their evaluation proctored.

Scheduling an OPI

To schedule an OPI, *please email your academic advisor, [Mitchell Lawson](#) or [Carly James](#)*. Please use the **subject line** "Schedule OPI" and provide the following information in the body of the email:

- First and Last name
- Student ID
- Language in which you would like to test
- Two preferred testing dates and times – OPI's can be scheduled **Monday, Wednesday and Friday (8:00 AM- 3:30 PM)**.

OPI's must be scheduled 48 hours prior to your desired test date/time.

The cost to take the OPI is \$66, which the student is responsible to pay.

There are practice tests and information about the assessment available [here](#).

Languages Tested through ALTA:

Albanian	Croatian	Jamaican Patois	Romanian
Amharic	Czech	Japanese	Russian
Arabic	Danish	Karenni	Samoan
<i>Arabic Dialects:</i>	Dari	Kazakh	Serbian
Arabic (Egyptian)	Dutch	Kinyarwanda	Sinhala
Arabic (Iraqi)	Fante (Akan)	Korean	Slovak
Arabic (Jordanian)	Farsi	Kurdish (Kurmanji)	Slovenian
Arabic (Lebanese)	Finnish	Kurdish (Sorani)	Somali
Arabic (Moroccan)	French	Latvian	Spanish
Arabic (Saudi Arabian)	French Canadian	Laotian	Swahili
Arabic (Sudanese)	Ga	Lithuanian	Swedish
Arabic (Syrian)	Georgian	Macedonian	Tagalog

Arabic (Yemeni) Armenian Azerbaijani Bambara Baluchi (Western) Bengali Bosnian Bulgarian Burmese Cambodian Cape Verdean (Balavento) Cape Verdean (Sotavento) Chinese (Cantonese) Chinese (Mandarin) Chuukese Afrikaans	German Greek Gujarati Haitian Creole Hausa Hebrew Hindi Hmong Hungarian Ibo Ilocano Indonesian Italian	Malay Malayalam Mongolian Navajo Nepali Norwegian Oromo Pashto Pashto (Pakistan) Polish Portuguese (Brazil) Portuguese (Portugal) Punjabi (Eastern) Punjabi (Western)	Tajik Tamil Telugu Thai Tibetan Tigrinya Turkish Turkmen Twi (Akan) Ukrainian Urdu Uzbek Vietnamese Wolof Yoruba
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Expectations for the OPI:

Thunderbird students must reach a level of either **Intermediate High** or **Intermediate Low** on their OPI depending upon the language they choose. Students should choose a language in which they have high proficiency.

<u>INTERMEDIATE HIGH- Level 7:</u> At this level, a student can use and understand the present, past and future tenses with some errors. The student does not use advanced tenses. The student can easily participate in a conversation on basic subjects like weather, but not in a general conversation. The student usually cannot understand normal native rates of speech.	<u>INTERMEDIATE LOW- Level 5:</u> At this level, a student has the ability to participate in basic conversations. The subjects are routine in nature and tend to be repetitive, for example weather. The student uses primarily the present tense and cannot use advanced tenses, thus is very restricted on expressing and understanding any subject other than what is most familiar to them. Speech is slow, and the student requires more rephrasing and repetition to understand a native speaker.
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Language Groups

GROUP 1 LANGUAGES Required Level: Intermediate High French Spanish German Portuguese Italian	GROUP 2 LANGUAGES Required Level: Intermediate Low Arabic Chinese Japanese Russian Korean All other languages provided by ALTA
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F1 Visa Students and the Language Requirement

Students who are completing their graduate degree and hold an F1 Visa may still need to complete the language requirement.

If you are a student on a F1 Visa from one of the countries listed below, you may still need to complete the language requirement. These countries/entities recognize English as an official language by law.

Therefore, it's possible that a student who is from one of the countries may not meet the language requirement via high school/college transcripts or the IELTS (International English Language Testing System) or PTE (Pearson English Language Test) which are conducted during the admissions process.

So, although a student on a F1 Visa may be fluent in a second language, you may still need to meet the language requirement. Please see below for a list of countries that may apply:

Antigua & Barbuda	Bahamas	Barbados
Belize	Botswana	Burundi
Cameroon	Canada	Cooks Island
Dominica	Eswatini	Fiji
The Gambia	Ghana	Grenada
Guyana	India	Ireland
Jamaica	Kenya	Kiribati
Lesotho	Liberia	Malawi
Marshall Islands	Mauritius	Federal States of Micronesia
Namibia	Nigeria	Niue
Pakistan	Palau	Papua New Guinea
Philippines	Rwanda	St Kitts and Nevis
St Lucia	St Vincent and the Grenadines	Samoa
Seychelles	Sierra Leone	Singapore
Solomon Islands	South Africa	South Sudan
Sudan	Tanzania	Tonga
Trinidad and Tobago	Tuvalu	Uganda
Vanuatu	Zambia	Zimbabwe
Akrotiri and Dhekelia	American Samoa	Anguilla
Bermuda	British Virgin Islands	Cayman Islands
U.S. Virgin Islands	Curacao	Falkland Islands
Guam	Hong Kong	Isle of Man
Jersey	Norfolk Island	Pitcairn Island
Puerto Rico	St Maarten	Turks and Caicos Islands

If you are from the following countries and you need to meet the language requirement, please review the options on page 1.